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Reading Response #1: Understanding
Women's Privacy Concerns Toward Period-Tracking Apps in the
Post Roe v. Wade Era – Cao et. al

Summary: Following the overturn of Roe v. Wade, this study investigates women's privacy perceptions regarding period-tracking apps. The researchers conducted a vignette-based survey of 183 US women, being sure to keep a balance between abortion-banned and abortion-legal states. The main takeaways from the paper are that while women express concern over data sharing with law enforcement and third parties, they generally feel like they have less agency in mitigating these risks (besides just deleting the apps). They also found that women's concerns about privacy were heavily influenced by who their data is shared with; sharing data with law enforcement triggered the most concern. Furthermore, their study found that there was a strong aversion to unnecessary data collection, like location or intimacy data considering that these are period tracking apps. I think this study's strengths and limitations both show up in the demographic they chose to study. On the one hand, this study does a good job equally representing women from states with anti-abortion policies and those without. Still, this study is lacking in racial representativeness, as Black and Hispanic women were underrepresented compared to US Census data. This is concerning given that abortion bans unequally impact marginalized and underrepresented groups. One question I have is, why did participants see law enforcement access as their top concern yet generally fail to connect this fear to the overturn of Roe v. Wade (a legal decision!)?

Reaction: The distinction users drew between necessary and irrelevant data was super interesting; participants seemed relatively comfortable with the collection of menstrual cycle data but were uncomfortable with the collection of location, intimacy, and mental health data. I found this surprising because, while these apps' primary goal is to track your period, I've found that the online wave of holistic medicine encourages people to connect their mental health and environmental factors into their analysis of their cycle (or maybe this is just TikTok). It was also interesting that Republican participants expressed significantly higher concern about data practices than Democrats. I think the findings from this study could inform inclusive technology development by making us think critically about how an app user's perception of the app's usefulness can dictate our data collection choices. While extra new and shiny features in an app can seem exciting, this study makes me think that additional features, like location or mental health tracking, can actually be counterproductive to the app's goal by decreasing user trust in the app.